

| By Damayanti Datta |

Here GIS geeks hammer away, rapt, at satellite maps and 3D models. Star achievers walk around in T-shirts that read, "You are following a... genius". Office "buddies" roll out the welcome wagon for new hires, while colleagues send each other appreciative notes during the Mutual Admiration Week. If you don't find them in office cubes, they are sure to be away for a spot of yoga, meditation, pranic or chair-therapy. They could also be in the canteen, duelling guitars. Or, perhaps, in old-age homes, cheering up the elderly on company time. Well-being is a way of life here: from lifestyle assessments, dental and eye check-ups, nutrition and diet watch, quit-smoking sessions, stress-busting and sleep disorder cures to tips on parenting, relationships, financial planning and personal grooming. Decision-making percolates down the ladder and the operating ethos is, "Let's have fun." So much so that employees get to calculate their own bonus. It's the story of RMSI, a Noida-based geographic information systems company, that has been winning kudos as India's "best workplace" with the best employee wellness initiatives.

The secret of RMSI's success lies in decoding the new landscape. For, wellness is the new metaphor for life in balance on the corporate corridors. Over 20 per cent of corporate employees in India crave to strike the right balance in life, reports a C-McKinsey 2009 study. Scratch beneath that craving and there's an unsettling world of long work hours, strict deadlines, sleep debt, precipitous drop in physical activity, unholy reliance on fat-laden foods of convenience and vicious stress loop at home and work spiralling into an abyss of chronic lifestyle disorders. In the midst of this gloomy picture, however, a new prescription is emerging. At its core are the new "P" words—prevention, pampering, purchasing power—and the simple yet powerful notion that people have far more control over their health than they realise. No wonder, two in every five Indian corporates are adding wellness programmes, reports IIR consulting firm Mercer (2009): if PepsiCo rewarded employees for losing flab, Hewlett-Packard employees got online health profiles, Maruti Suzuki and LG pro-



In Search of **WELLNESS**

Corporate warriors of the new economy are driving a new health movement and spawning a market sizzling with potential